

GOAL RUSH

Records tumbled as the Champions League delivered its most **explosive** week this season.

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A record 71 goals were scored across the 18 games, with 11 of those matches featuring at least four goals. Defending champion Paris Saint-Germain was the standout performer, registering a chaotic 7-2 win against Bayer Leverkusen in a tie that had five first-half goals, two red cards, and two penalties. Six different players got their names on the scoresheet, with French youngster Desire Doue bagging a brace, while his compatriot and Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele also scored on his return from a six-week injury lay-off.

Last season's semifinalist, Barcelona, also posted a five-goal victory, thumping Olympiakos 6-1. The Catalans capitalised on a second-half red card to blow away their opposition with four goals in 11 minutes, as Fermin Lopez grabbed his first career hat-trick, Marcus Rashford netted twice, and Lamine Yamal (**above**) converted from the spot. Rashford seems to have rediscovered his form and now has four goals and two assists in three Champions League games for Barcelona. Only Real Madrid's Kylian Mbappe and Bayern Munich's Harry Kane have more (five). Just like Barcelona, Chelsea also took advantage of an early red card to beat Ajax 5-1.

The visitors' captain, Kenneth Taylor, was shown a straight red in the 17th minute for a dangerous tackle, which opened the floodgates for the Blues. Marc Guiu scored in the following minute, while Moises Caicedo, Estevao, Enzo Fernandez and Tyrique George also found the back of the net.

England captain Kane scored in his third consecutive

Champions League game as Bayern beat Club Brugge 4-0. The game also witnessed a slice of history as 17-year-old Lennart Karl became the youngest German scorer in the competition, producing an excellent finish from outside the box just five minutes into the match on his first start in the tournament.

Arsenal's tie with Atletico Madrid was the most high-profile fixture of the week, with friction between the clubs starting even before kick-off.

Atletico's players were reportedly upset with the lack of hot water in the Emirates Stadium dressing room on the eve of the match, prompting them to end their training session early. However, the episode seemed to have taken the fire out of the Atletico players, as they slumped to a 4-0 defeat, managing only one shot on target. Brazilians Gabriel Magalhães and Gabriel Martinelli gave Arsenal a healthy lead before Viktor Gyokeres scored two goals in three minutes to end his nine-game goal drought for club and country.

Napoli suffered the only upset of the week, handed a 2-6 thrashing by Dutch champion PSV Eindhoven.

Meanwhile, Champions League regulars Real Madrid, Manchester City, Inter Milan, Liverpool, and Borussia Dortmund all produced convincing performances to take all three points from their games.

Azerbaijani club Qarabağ FK's loss against Athletic Club means that only five teams — PSG, Bayern, Inter, Arsenal, and Real Madrid — have perfect records after three matches. At the other end, Ajax and Benfica have endured a horrific start to their campaigns, with three losses each.

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